

importance of intelligence gathering and, therefore, prevention of such attacks, Chidambaram decided to start from the top by personally conducting the review meetings with heads of key agencies. The idea, he says with a smile, is essentially to let everybody know what each has got so that nobody says he didn't know.

Chidambaram then energised the Multi-Agency Centre (MAC) which had the representatives of all agencies interacting on a 24x7 basis to share intelligence and analyse it on a real-time basis. At the state level, he backed it by setting up State MACs in every capital and connecting them with dedicated communication equipment to the Centre so that

preparation that saw troops waiting for city buses to transport them to the scene of the attack and the lack of coordination among various agencies leading to confusion disturbed him. So among the first things he did was to order four more hubs for the NSG in the country: Mumbai, Hyderabad, Kolkata and Chennai so that the response time would be swift and decisive. Union Home Secretary G.K. Pillai recalls that Chidambaram set June 30 as the target "and then sat on everybody's head, said it was no longer business as usual and got the job done on schedule".

Chidambaram brings to the Home Ministry a corporate-like efficiency with an excellent eye for detail. Pillai says,

"He always wants things done yesterday and pays great attention to detail. He gives clear instructions so that everybody knows what to do. He then follows it up to make sure it is done." With Prime Minister Manmohan Singh giving him a free hand, Chidambaram has sufficient clout to push through reforms that he wants. At cabinet meetings, he is not afraid to speak his mind. His only drawback, according to a state home secretary, is that he "doesn't have the political maturity and sensitivity that Patil brought to the job and can be impatient and brusque". His 'know-it-all' demeanour is a put off for many.

Some of that showed up earlier in his tenure while dealing with state chief ministers. He had Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar complain about a peremptory letter that Chidambaram had written to them when the prime minister had convened a 26/11 review meeting. Chidambaram admits that he doesn't believe in "genuflecting" to get the job done. But he has since learnt some lessons. He now sends out letters to all the key ministers and officials involved to file details of the action taken. Reason: no one can wriggle out saying they hadn't been informed. He knows that getting the states reform their police forces is key to improving India's level of preparedness against terror attacks.

Chidambaram's eyes are firmly focussed on the long-term as well. The setting up of a National Counter-Terrorism Centre that would not only act as the nodal agency for processing intelligence but also act on it is on the drawing board. He is getting states to beef up their own quick reaction teams and counter-terrorism forces besides plugging the gaps on coastal security. Even as he focuses on cross-border terror he has to take steps on lessening the threat from Naxals, apart from quelling insurgents in the north-east and starting a "quiet dialogue" with Kashmiri separatist groups. He admits that there "is still plenty to be done" and there is need to rationalise the division of work in the ministry. He dismisses all talk of him being indispensable to the system or criticism that he has not been able to institutionalise reforms. He says, "If another home minister takes over, he can do the same job if he is interested." Yes Sir, but there is only one P. Chidambaram. ■

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WHAT HE'S DONE

- Beefed up intelligence by personally conducting review meetings and revamped the Multi-Agency Centres.

- Enhanced response by setting up four more hubs for NSG and funding states to set up counter-terrorism force.

- Cut out red tape and speeded up purchases.

WHAT HE HAS NOT

- Ensuring that the states reform their police urgently, including filling up vacancies and improving training facilities.

- Rationalising the Home Ministry's functioning and possibly separating internal security from the host of routine tasks entrusted to it.

everyone was in touch round the clock. This is to be a forerunner of a national intelligence grid that he is planning to set up which would integrate all intelligence agencies, including the armed forces for greater coordination. He also beefed up the number of personnel in intelligence agencies. One example of how the system works: when Headley mentioned "Rahul" in several communications, within hours they had determined that it was not Rahul Gandhi but Rahul Bhatt, a wannabe actor, whom he had contact with.

Even as he set out to revamp India's intelligence gathering network, Chidambaram focussed on beefing up the swiftness of response to terror attacks. The delay in the NSG reaching Mumbai by flight from Delhi, the inadequate